

NEPED Society

NEPED was formed in 1994, with officers drawn from various state government departments. Nagaland's first foreign aided project funded by CIDA (Canadian International Development Agency) under ICEF (Indo-Canada Environment Facility) was successfully implemented by NEPED. The Project Operations Unit (POU) members form the hub of NEPED. The team consists of versatile, dedicated and well trained professionals drawn from various line departments. NEPED is advised and supported by a well appointed Project Steering Committee headed by the Chief Secretary. Added to this, is an informal and highly conducive work culture and environment that strongly supports innovation and the result is a recipe for success.

The purpose of the society is, to care and manage issues, linked with sustainable development, for employment generation, and utilize human resources of the state, by way of coordinating with all developmental departments in the state. The society shall seek fund, and implement external funding related to environmental issues, and poverty reduction. The objective of the Society is to carry out studies and identify major issues, which need to be addressed from time to time, and to generate and adapt technologies, which promote sustainable use of natural resources and improve livelihood options.

Major Projects Implemented by NEPED

The first phase of the project, NEPED-I undertook a project for planting trees along with *jhum* (slash and burn/ Shifting cultivation) practiced by different tribes in Nagaland. The project has established 1794 test plots (2 test plots each, measuring 3 hectares per village) in *jhum* fields in 854 villages across all the 8 districts covering all 16 tribes of Nagaland. More than 7.8 million economic trees were planted in 5500 hectares with replication ratio of 1:6. Through this project more than 7000 farmers and 2000 state government officials had undergone various training programmes for capacity development.

The second phase, NEPED-II had focus on creating a micro credit mechanism in the villages, through which a paradigm shift from subsidy oriented mindset of the people towards self-reliance was created. About 7888 farmers were benefited by growing cash crops with Rs 825 crores in all the 8 districts of Nagaland. The women groups and formal SHGs were also empowered to access the village funds. The women, for the first time in the history of Nagaland, had purchased 30 plots of lands by breaking the barriers of the traditional laws. They cultivate vegetable and other short term crops in these plots and recovered the loans by selling the farm produces.

The third phase, NEPED-III is concentrated on consolidating the achievements of the first two phases through watershed development. An area of 17,930 ha of arable and non-arable land was treated employing soil erosion control measures. Through this project another 6600 *jhumias* were assisted with a menu of land based livelihood activities such as

piggery, poultry, goatery, rabbitry, apiculture, blacksmith, carpentry, weaving, rice mills, fishery, basketry, carving etc.

To develop mechanisms for the community conservation efforts in Nagaland, NEPED had played advocacy role, wherein communities were advised to set aside areas within village lands, with restrictions on hunting, fishing and logging by way of resolutions passed by the village councils. Conservation of our natural resources will strengthen biodiversity leading to livelihood benefits.

NEPED in collaboration with Salim Ali Center for Ornithology & Natural History (SACON) has implemented NEPED-SCEN program in Nagaland funded by Sir Dorabji Ratan Tata Trust (SDTT) with the following objectives of formation of joint community conservation areas:

1. To assist villages, which have or propose to have community conservation areas, in developing biodiversity registers, resource maps and management plans, and develop the process by which biodiversity registers are legally protected.
2. Advocate and assist in the establishment of community conservation areas where such efforts are currently lacking.
3. Documentation of indigenous Ecological Knowledge.
4. Identify technical, developmental and financial requirements of community conservation areas
5. Provide necessary technical support and linkages to information, processes, markets and developmental programs to the villages who are developing community conservation areas
6. Use the Blyth's Trogon which is the state bird of Nagaland as a flag-ship species in enhancing conservation reach.

Success stories:

Over the last 25 years, NEPED has acquired considerable credibility across Nagaland and beyond. The emerging need for the agro-enterprises that have risen from NEPED's effort, is to meet energy requirements necessitated to enable Naga farmers to compete in a global market. Hence, a dedicated team of multi-disciplinary experts has been formed by the Government of Nagaland, with full autonomy, to address the challenges brought about by these developmental achievements. NEPED's effort in bringing about a paradigm shift in the mindset of the rural folks had amassed immense credibility within the country, as well as from the international community. It had been serving as knowledge bank for researchers, related Government Departments, NGOs, etc. even from beyond national borders. In the renewable energy sector, till date, NEPED had installed 108 hydrogens (pico units) with generator capacity of 3KW all over the state. Most of the installed units are community based. More than ever, NEPED society has a bigger role to play foreseeing the challenges in transforming the society for a better world with the change of times. As such, NEPED has delivered extraordinary performance and excellent overall achievements consistent with the project objectives, particularly with respect to promotion of agro-forestry, development of demonstration models for jhum crop improvement, intensification, its sustainability, resource management and economic development, thrust on income generation and women empowerment. In 854 villages, covering 5500 hectares

across Nagaland, 1794 "test plots" were set up in jhum fields in 1995-2000. It was not just tree plantation, but micro planning with the villagers, equity based approach, empowering gaps assessed and addressed, land use system, erosion control, increasing productivity, identifying best/good practices, "Search & Find" and reviving of TKS (Traditional Knowledge System). The achievement in the transformation of tree farming/plantation into a state-wide movement has been exemplary. "NEPED's potential for mapping, conserving, developing and exploiting the enormous bio-diversity of the Northeast marks it out as a critical lead programme. The necessary funding, manpower development and other support required for its careful evaluation and refinement for replication or adoption elsewhere in the Region must be made available." Shukla Commission Report: Government of India, March 1997.

NEPED has been ushering in several inputs to the communities for a solution to alternative means of livelihoods by way of imparting different techniques, innovations and livestock models in rural areas. Till 2013, NEPED had assisted 4200 resource poor families under various projects (WDPSA funded by Ministry of Agriculture, GoI; Enhancing livelihood through community based piggery funded by NRTT and State Plan fund) across Nagaland by means of supplying pig breeding stock, fattening stock, construction of low cost scientific pig sties, improved feed and feeding practices, insurance and prevention & control of Classical Swine Fever (CSF). The introduction of Livestock Service Provider (LSP) model in project villages has significant impact in containing CSF that is responsible for loss of millions of rupees annually. Another innovation, designed and developed by NEPED is 'Foddorizer' which is helping rural farmers in improving feed and feeding practices of pig and reduction in firewood consumption to a tune of 1.5 lac trees per year.